

Silver Trust — Pain Point Discovery Table

Persona	Pain Point	How This Affects the Project
Robert Singh VP of Talent & Operations	- Capacity decisions for accepting new projects rely on gut feeling rather than real-time data. - Answering whether the firm can take a new project takes 2–3 days of manually chasing emails, digging through spreadsheets, and calling managers. - Even after all that effort, Robert said his answer is “not based on real data”, rather on gut feeling. - He described the process as a “nightmare” when managing 15–20 active projects simultaneously.	- The system must provide a real-time capacity dashboard consolidating consultant availability, current allocations, and workload data. - Replaces gut-feel decisions with data-driven ones. - Automated capacity forecasting is a core requirement, especially as the company scales toward ~50 consultants in 15 months. - Must reduce the 2–3 day decision cycle to near-instant.
Michelle Zhang Senior Project Manager	- All staffing knowledge lives in a personal spreadsheet (the “black book”) only she can fully interpret. - It contains consultant availability, skill gaps, interpersonal dynamics, and soft notes from hallway conversations (e.g., learning Keisha feels overwhelmed in the kitchen). - When Michelle is absent, the entire resourcing process breaks down — Robert said it takes him days to reconstruct. - Calendars are not always updated, requiring her to manually follow up with each consultant to confirm availability. - The spreadsheet does not integrate with JIRA, creating duplicate data entry and inconsistency.	- The system must digitize and structure the tacit knowledge currently locked in her spreadsheet. - A consultant profile system capturing skills, availability, past performance, interpersonal compatibility, and wellbeing signals is required. - The single-point-of-failure risk is critical: the solution must be fully usable by other PMs without Michelle present. - Integration between the staffing tool and JIRA is essential to eliminate double entry and keep data consistent.

Keisha Williams Senior Consultant	• Has not taken a vacation in three years and is stretched across the majority of active projects simultaneously. • Overextension means she cannot mentor junior staff despite this being an intended part of her role and her own stated priority. • Her availability is treated as a default fallback when no other consultant is suitable. • Burnout risk is only flagged reactively in HR meetings rather than detected proactively. • Clients frequently change requirements between meetings, dispute timelines and budgets, and occasionally remove the team due to cultural mismatch — adding pressure to already overloaded consultants.	• The system needs workload visibility and overallocation alerts per consultant. • Burnout risk tracking should be a proactive feature, not a reactive conversation. • Staffing logic should flag when a senior consultant is over capacity and suggest alternative combinations. • The client-side instability suggests a need for better change management and communication workflows to reduce delivery friction and rework for the consulting team.
David Park Junior Consultant	• Receives inconsistent mentoring because senior consultants are too overloaded to dedicate time. • Sometimes excluded from project meetings entirely, and sometimes “thrown into the fire” on complex projects — not as a deliberate development move, but because no one else is available. • Has no structured development path or visibility into what skills he is building or needs next. • Represents a broader pattern: the firm plans to grow significantly, but has no systematic approach to developing junior talent at scale.	• The system should support deliberate junior-senior pairing logic when allocating consultants, factoring in development goals alongside availability and skill fit. • A skill-tracking component per consultant would allow the system to recommend stretch assignments intentionally. • Essential for the firm’s planned growth from 30 to ~50 consultants: the talent pipeline depends on structured development, not ad hoc mentoring.
Silver Trust Cross-Functional / Operational	• Key operational information is fragmented across JIRA, spreadsheets, calendars, email, and informal knowledge held in individuals’ heads.	• The project should focus on workflow integration, knowledge capture, and operational resilience. • The solution must unify data sources, reduce bottlenecks

	• Not all teams use JIRA — accounting and procurement use different tools entirely, creating further fragmentation. • The GDPR and EU AI regulation landscape adds compliance requirements to any solution involving personal or performance data. • Some clients still communicate only by fax, reflecting the range of legacy communication workflows the team must accommodate.	from disconnected tools, and create a scalable operating model. • Compliance with GDPR and EU AI regulations must be built into the solution design from the start, not treated as a later consideration. • Communication layer flexibility (including legacy formats) should be accounted for in the system design.
Silver Trust Single Point of Failure Risk	• Critical staffing logic lives in one person's system and memory (Michelle's black book). • When Michelle is unavailable, Robert described the process taking "a lot of time" and requiring him to contact multiple PMs to reconstruct information. • The firm's ability to staff and start projects on time is structurally dependent on one individual's availability and knowledge retention.	• The project must include knowledge transfer, system transparency, and backup continuity as explicit requirements. • The solution must reduce reliance on one individual, make staffing logic visible and transferable, and ensure process continuity when any key manager is absent. • This is a risk that will only grow as the company scales.
Silver Trust Client-Facing	• Clients frequently change requirements between meetings, causing delivery friction, rework, and planning instability. • Budget disagreements and timeline disputes are common and described as a regular source of project slowdown. • Cultural mismatches (e.g., clients finding the team "too direct") have led to the firm being removed from projects. • There is no structured process for qualifying client fit upfront or managing expectation shifts systematically.	• The project may need to include client onboarding and communication tooling. • AI-assisted templates that adapt tone and communication style per client profile could reduce cultural friction. • Pattern recognition across past projects could flag early warning signs of difficult client relationships before they escalate. • This is a secondary but valuable scope addition that could directly improve project success rates.
Silver Trust Scaling & Culture	• The organization plans to grow from 30 to ~50 consultants within 15 months, but its current	• The solution cannot be overly rigid; it must capture internal knowledge and improve decisions while preserving

	operating model is heavily relationship-based and manual. • Many staffing and team-fit decisions are not systematized — they depend on informal knowledge, personal relationships, and institutional memory. • The current model works because the team is tight-knit and experienced, but it will not scale without structural support.	flexibility for human judgment and context-specific overrides. • The system must be designed to grow with the company, supporting an increasing number of consultants, projects, and PMs without requiring proportional increases in manual coordination effort. • Cultural continuity (the collaborative ethos Robert described) must be preserved in the design, not undermined by over-automation.
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Reflection on Interview Techniques

What worked well: The funnel approach — starting broad with role and workflow, then narrowing toward friction and data — was effective even when stakeholders were evasive. Questions framed around *time and effort* ("what takes the most time?", "how long does the capacity decision take?") consistently surfaced honest answers. Robert's admission that decisions take 2–3 days and rely on gut feeling came out through this framing, not through direct problem questions. Anson's "ideal scenario" question when Michelle wasn't present was particularly powerful — it got Robert to articulate the bottleneck clearly without feeling defensive about it.

What didn't work: Following a pre-scripted structure in a live, dynamic conversation was difficult. The stakeholders were frequently evasive or deflecting ("we deliver in the best way possible"), and a linear script made it hard to chase those deflections naturally. Multiple interviewers asking questions in sequence also created a Q&A feel rather than a real diagnostic conversation, which reduced rapport and made transitions abrupt.

What to do differently: Assigning clear roles — one primary interviewer, one note-taker, one timekeeper, and one person responsible for synthesis and follow-up probing — would have created better flow and prevented questions from stacking on top of each other. A single steering voice builds more trust and makes it easier to pick up on hesitation or contradiction, like when Michelle insisted the spreadsheet "doesn't slow her down" while simultaneously describing a system only she can operate. That tension deserved a deeper probe. That said, the team still managed to surface the core pain points, which confirms the structured preparation paid off even when the execution was imperfect.

Examples of Interview Questions

Here are some examples of interview questions that actually drew substantive responses:

- **"Can you walk us through your current processes?"** Triggered the workflow explanation covering JIRA, email notifications, spreadsheets, and calendar cross-referencing — the most complete picture of how the firm operates.
- **"Which parts take the most time?"** Got Robert to open up about the 2–3 day capacity decision cycle, chasing emails, digging through spreadsheets, and making gut-feel calls.
- **"Which part of the process is manual?"** Directly unlocked Robert's most candid moment — admitting decisions aren't based on real data and describing the process as a "nightmare."

- **"How would this process work in an ideal scenario when Michelle is not present?"** Confirmed the single-point-of-failure risk and got Robert to articulate the dependency on her black book explicitly.
- **"What would be one thing to change to prepare for scaling?"** Reinforced the capacity planning pain point and got Robert to describe the back-and-forth project acceptance process as the core bottleneck.
- **"What might make your life easier?"** (to David) Surfaced the junior consultant's lack of structured development and his awareness of being left out or thrown in at the deep end.
- **"Is the information always available when you need it?" / calendar follow-up** Got Michelle to reveal that consultants don't reliably update their calendars, adding a hidden manual step to her already complex staffing process.